

Mauritius SME Automation Agency — Critical Feasibility Study

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Mauritius SME Automation Agency — Critical Feasibility Study

Beachhead case study: Méhua Lashes | Prepared as a sceptical investment-style review

Evidence key used throughout: **[INTERVIEW]** = from the Méhua Lashes discovery workbook · **[RESEARCH]** = external web research, cited · **[ASSUMPTION]** = stated assumption, not verified · **[INFERENCE]** = reasoned conclusion drawn from the above, flagged as such.

Executive summary

The underlying pain is real and well-evidenced: Méhua Lashes’ owner loses meaningful time every week to manual deposit verification, WhatsApp/Instagram enquiry handling, and has no rebooking or lapsed-client process at all, leaving revenue on the table **[INTERVIEW]**. But three findings should stop you from immediately calling this a “Strong Go”:

- 1. The one price signal you have is a red flag, not a green light.** The interviewee said she’d pay under Rs5,000 *one-time* and under Rs500/month **[INTERVIEW]** — a price point that likely sits below your own hosting/API/messaging costs per client once you leave the free tier of WhatsApp’s Business App, and roughly **6–20x lower** than what an already-operating Mauritius competitor publicly charges beauty-sector clients for a similar (or lighter) service **[RESEARCH]**.
- 2. The market is not empty.** At least one Mauritius-based agency (SME Advantage) is already selling WhatsApp/Instagram automation, booking, and reputation-management packages to beauty businesses specifically, with named beauty-sector testimonials, and several other local and regional players (A3 Mauritius, Webymind, Kipps.AI, and 10+ listed chatbot developers) compete in adjacent automation categories **[RESEARCH]**. This is a validate-and-differentiate market, not a blue ocean.
- 3. Fresha, the system of record, has no public API, no webhooks, and no Zapier/Make listing** — only a read-only finance-data connector **[RESEARCH]**. Anything you build “around” Fresha has to work through WhatsApp/Instagram and manual/semi-manual data entry, not a clean integration. This directly shapes (and limits) what “automation” can mean here, and it’s a platform-dependency risk that a single vendor decision (Fresha shipping its own AI concierge, which it has already begun doing in 2026 **[RESEARCH]**) could undercut.

None of this kills the idea. It does mean: **do not build software yet**, price discovery from one family member is not evidence of market willingness to pay, and the strongest version of this business is narrower and more human-in-the-loop than “AI automation agency” branding usually implies.

Overall verdict: Validate before building, with a recommended narrow first pilot (Section 3) and a structured 8–12 interview validation phase (Section 15) before any code is written. Full scoring and reasoning in Section 17.

1. Discovery evidence — what the interview actually shows

The workbook is unusually disciplined about separating owner evidence from inference, and this report preserves that discipline. Confidence categories used below:

- **Confirmed** — a direct owner answer, unambiguous.
- **Reasonable inference** — the workbook’s own cross-question synthesis, logically supported but not a direct quote.
- **Unvalidated hypothesis** — plausible, stated as a hope/idea, not tested.
- **Discard** — contradicted by the owner’s own answers or explicitly rejected by her.

Top operational problems, ranked by the workbook's own Opportunity Scoring sheet

#	Problem	Confidence	What currently happens	Who feels it	Frequency	Cost type	Current tool	Already solved by existing platform?	Automation warranted?	Ease	Reusability across other salons
1	Deposit reminder, proof-of-payment intake & confirmation	Confirmed	Client books on Fresha → pays via Juice/bank transfer <i>outside</i> Fresha → sends WhatsApp screenshot → owner manually checks bank/Juice → owner manually sends confirmation + policy + location	Owner (admin load) + client (confusion, forgotten deposits)	Several times/week, every booking	Time + revenue (unconfirmed bookings) + CX	WhatsApp + Juice/bank statements + Fresha	No — Fresha's deposit/payment feature exists but the owner reports not using it for this flow [INTERVIEW Q70] ; no bank-to-chat reconciliation tool is in use	Yes, but only the reminder/intake/confirmation shell — not payment verification itself (see Section 3)	Medium	High
2	General enquiry handling (IG/WhatsApp)	Confirmed	~10+ WhatsApp + ~4-5 Instagram enquiries/week, ~10 minutes and ~4 messages each, response time up to 48h in hours and 48h+ outside hours; messages sometimes forgotten entirely	Owner (time, interruption during services) + client (repeat messages, drop-off risk)	Daily/several times weekly	Time + possible lost leads	Instagram + WhatsApp	Partially — owner already uses WhatsApp Business quick replies and IG saved replies [INTERVIEW Q47-49] , so some of this is a configuration gap, not a build gap	Yes, for the routine ~20% of message types (price/availability/link); no for technical lash-selection advice, which owner explicitly wants kept human [INTERVIEW Q43]	Medium-High	High
3	Rebooking & lapsed-client reactivation	Confirmed	Only ~30% of clients rebook before leaving; no reminder system exists; no one is ever proactively re-contacted after lapsing	Owner (missed revenue)	Structural / ongoing	Revenue (highest-uptake item in the whole discovery)	Fresha (passive only)	No — owner confirms Fresha cannot currently do this the way she wants [INTERVIEW Q109]	Yes	Medium	High
4	No structured client/technical record	Confirmed	Lash mapping/curl/length/g lue/sensitivities are not recorded anywhere; before/after photos live unsorted on the owner's phone	Owner (prep time, repeated recall)	Weekly	Time + moderate CX	Phone / memory	No	Marginal — lower-value, more of a personal productivity fix than a monetisable product	Medium	Maybe (depends on tech literacy of adopter)
5	No inventory/stock visibility	Confirmed	No system at all; stock checked physically; runs out roughly every 2 months and has already caused a disrupted appointment	Owner + client (when it bites)	Every ~2 months	Time + occasional service disruption	None	No	Yes, but keep extremely light — owner explicitly rejects detailed tracking [INTERVIEW Q166]	High (easy)	Yes
6	No weekly KPI / profit-margin visibility	Confirmed	Revenue, revenue-by-service, and profit margin are "not quick" to produce; owner reconciles from bank statements	Owner	Weekly/monthly	Decision-quality	Fresha finance export (limited) + bank statements	Partially — Fresha exports finance data but the owner's access appears limited [INTERVIEW Q86]	Yes, as a lightweight recurring report, not a full BI dashboard	Medium	High
7	No lead/enquiry status tracking or source attribution	Confirmed	Lost leads tracked "from memory"; booking source (IG vs WhatsApp vs referral) cannot be determined	Owner	Weekly	Insight gap, not urgent pain	WhatsApp/memory	No	Investigate, not build — owner explicitly said she does <i>not</i> currently want an automatic CRM linking IG/WhatsApp to Fresha [INTERVIEW Q85]	Medium	Medium
8	Cancellation/no-show recovery	Confirmed	Infrequent; ~48h notice typical; a waitlist already exists inside Fresha and is described by the	Low impact currently	Low (monthly)	~Rs2,000 per lost slot, rarely triggered	Fresha	Yes, largely — owner explicitly says the automated-waitlist concept is "already done"	No — deprioritised by the workbook's own scoring (raw score 16 vs 625 for the top item)	—	—

			discarded by the owner as “already done”					already done [INTERVIEW Q99]	rejection		
9	Social media content creation load	Confirmed pain, discard as automation target	Editing/planning consumes significant time	Owner	Weekly	Time	Instagram + phone	No	Explicitly rejected by the owner as something she wants automated — brand-voice risk [INTERVIEW Q10, Q181]	—	—

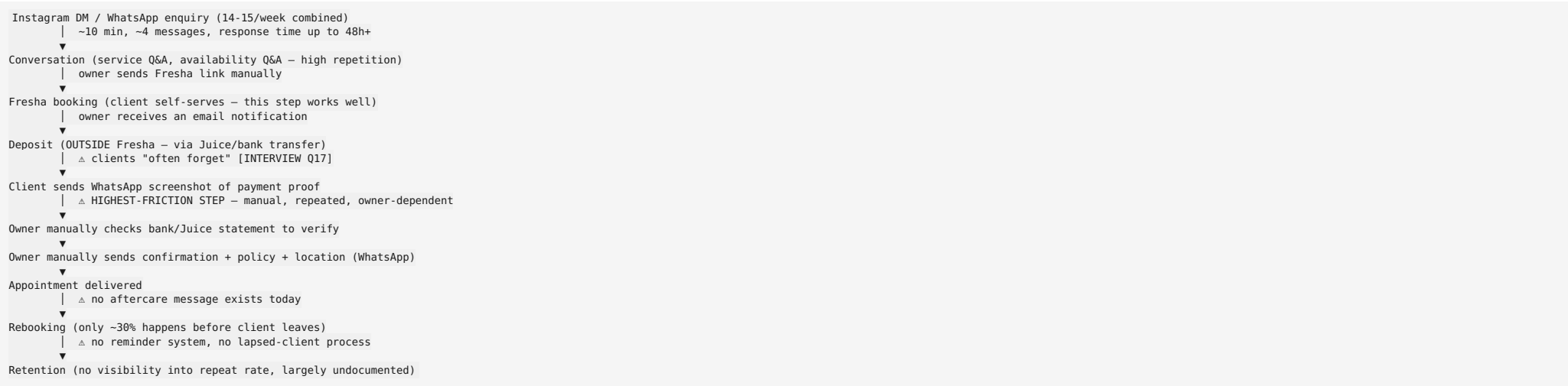
Discard pile (raised, then knocked out by the owner’s own answers): automatic lead-record creation from IG/WhatsApp into a CRM (Q85 — “no”); automated follow-up to abandoned enquiries (Q55 — “no need”); high-intent unbooked alerts (Q84 — “no need”); automated waitlist contact (Q99 — already exists); AI-generated social content (Q146, Q181 — explicitly rejected).

What this leaves you with

Two things are simultaneously true and both matter for a feasibility call:

- The **strongest, most repeatable, most owner-desired problem is deposit/booking-admin friction**, exactly as the workbook’s own pilot recommendation concludes.
- The **second-strongest, highest-revenue-upside problem is retention** (rebooking + lapsed-client reactivation) — arguably a *better* commercial pitch than the deposit workflow, because “we get your old clients to come back” is easier to sell and price on outcome than “we make your admin smoother” (see Section 8 on positioning).

2. The Instagram/WhatsApp → Fresha handoff, mapped



Where money/time/customers are actually lost, in order of evidence strength:

1. **The deposit step** — the single most repeated manual task in the business, the one the owner names unprompted as her top pain (Q6, Q9, Q18, Q20, Q44, Q175, Q176, Q179), and the one clients most often stumble on.
2. **The retention step** — not a “friction” in the workflow-diagram sense, but a pure absence: nothing happens after the appointment. 70% of clients leave without a next booking and nobody follows up.
3. **Response-time drag on enquiries** — up to 48 working hours is a slow reply for a beauty business competing on Instagram, though the owner’s own ~75% estimated enquiry-to-booking conversion (unvalidated, self-reported) suggests this isn’t currently costing as many bookings as the raw delay number implies.

What this evidence does *not* support: replacing Fresha, building a full CRM, or automating content creation. The workbook’s own “key principle” (don’t replace Fresha; fix the gaps around it) is correct and should stay the operating constraint for any MVP.

3. Evaluating the proposed first pilot: deposit → verification → confirmation

Proposed flow: Fresha booking → deposit/payment instructions → client sends WhatsApp proof → payment status checked → booking confirmed → policy/location sent.

Question	Assessment
Technically feasible?	Yes, for the messaging shell (reminders, proof intake, templated confirmation). No , not yet, for automatic payment verification — see below.
Commercially valuable?	Moderate. It removes the owner’s most annoying task, but it is an <i>efficiency</i> story, not a <i>revenue-growth</i> story, which matters for how easy it is to price (Section 8–9).
What can realistically be automated in phase 1?	Automatic deposit-instruction message immediately after a Fresha booking notification is received; automatic reminder if no proof has arrived after N hours; structured intake of the proof image/text into a simple log; automatic policy/location message <i>after</i> the owner marks payment verified.
What should stay human?	Payment verification itself. Matching a screenshot or bank/Juice line item to a specific booking reliably, without false positives, needs either (a) Fresha’s own deposit feature turned on and used as source of truth, or (b) direct read access to the Juice/bank account, which is a materially bigger, higher-risk integration than anything else in this project. The owner also explicitly wants to retain “somewhat controlled” oversight of client-facing messages [INTERVIEW Q183] , even though she separately says she’d prefer full automation where safe [INTERVIEW Q184] — a real tension worth resolving with her directly, not resolving in your favour by assumption.
Should payment verification stay manual initially?	Yes. The workbook’s own recommended pilot reaches the same conclusion. This is also the safer regulatory posture — see Section 12 on Mauritius data protection.
Would WhatsApp Business API be required?	Only if you want message flows to trigger automatically without the owner’s phone being the sending device, or if you want to send outside the 24-hour free service window. For a single-client pilot, the free WhatsApp Business App with quick replies and manual/semi-manual triggering (e.g., an n8n flow that <i>drafts</i> the message and the owner taps send) avoids WhatsApp Business Platform costs and ToS risk entirely. This is the right choice for a pilot; API is a later-stage decision (see Section 11).
Do Meta messaging restrictions create issues?	Yes, if you go to the API: business-initiated messages outside a 24-hour customer window must use pre-approved templates and, as of policy changes effective through 2026, most template <i>and</i> increasingly service-window messages are billable per message, with costs varying by category and recipient country [RESEARCH] . For a pilot at 1 client and low volume this is a minor dollar cost but a real complexity cost (template approval, BSP account, quality-rating management).
Does Fresha have an API/webhooks/exports that support this?	No public API, no webhooks, no Zapier/Make app. The only programmatic surface is a read-only Data Connector under Reports, intended for BI, not automation triggers [RESEARCH] . This is the single most important technical constraint in the whole project: you cannot get a real-time “a booking just happened” event from Fresha.
Is browser automation appropriate?	It’s the only way to get anything Fresha doesn’t expose (e.g., watching the bookings calendar or inbox programmatically), but it is fragile by nature (breaks on UI changes), sits in a legal/ToS grey zone Fresha could act on, and is a poor foundation for a product you intend to resell to multiple clients. Recommendation: avoid it as the trigger mechanism. Instead, trigger the automation from the email notification Fresha already sends on every booking (parse the booking email via a mail-parsing step in n8n/Zapier-equivalent) or from a manual “new booking” button the owner presses. Both are unglamorous but reliable.
Implementation complexity	Medium. The message-sequencing logic is simple; the two hard parts are (a) reliably detecting a new booking without an API, and (b) keeping the WhatsApp side within a channel the owner is comfortable with.
Ongoing maintenance burden	Medium, driven almost entirely by fragility of the “detect a new Fresha booking” step and by WhatsApp template/policy drift, not by the business logic itself.
Privacy/security considerations	Deposit proofs are financial documents; client phone numbers and payment status are personal data under the Mauritius Data Protection Act 2017 (Section 12). Keep bank details out of any third-party tool per the owner’s own stated boundary [INTERVIEW Q129] .
Failure modes	False “payment verified” state if verification is ever automated prematurely (brand-damaging — the owner names this as her worst-case scenario, Q203); WhatsApp number/template getting flagged as spam; Fresha changing its booking-email format and silently breaking the trigger.
Realistic development time	1–2 weeks for a working, single-client, human-in-the-loop version using n8n + WhatsApp Business App/quick replies + email-parsing trigger.
Approximate operating cost	Roughly Rs800–2,500/month per client at this scale (automation platform + minimal LLM calls for message drafting + contingency), assuming you avoid the paid WhatsApp Business Platform initially.
Realistic price to charge	Given the WTP evidence in Section 9, a genuinely justifiable price for <i>this specific business</i> looks more like Rs3,000–7,000 setup and Rs500–1,000/month than the brief’s proposed Rs5,000–20,000/Rs1,500 — unless you can prove enough time/revenue recovered to justify more, or unless other salons (not related to you) turn out to value it more highly than family-discount pricing suggests.

Is this the best first pilot? It is defensible, but **the retention pilot (rebooking + lapsed-client reactivation) may be commercially stronger** as a *second* pilot to build in parallel or immediately after, because: (a) it doesn’t depend on solving the Fresha-has-no-API problem for a real-time trigger — a weekly export/manual list is good enough; (b) its value is denominated in recovered revenue, not saved minutes, which is a much easier number to sell on; and (c) 70% non-rebooking is a bigger number than any efficiency saving in the deposit flow. **Recommendation: build the deposit-workflow pilot first (as the workbook concludes, because it’s the highest-scored and most requested by the owner), but design the retention/reactivation flow as pilot #2 within the same 30-day window**, since it reuses the same messaging infrastructure and is structurally simpler (no real-time trigger needed).

4. Other product concepts, scored

Concept	Customer pain	Business value	Tech difficulty	Setup cost	Ongoing cost	Integration dependence	Reliability risk	Ease of sale	Repeatability	WTP estimate	Pricing model	Scalability	Recommendation
A. Enquiry/FAQ automation	High (evidenced)	Medium	Low-Medium	Low	Low	WhatsApp/IG only	Low	Medium	High	Medium	Setup + monthly support	High	Build Now (as part of pilot #1)

B. Abandoned-enquiry follow-up	Present but owner said “no need” for her own business	Unproven	Low	Low	Low	WhatsApp/IG	Low	Depends heavily on brand tone risk	Medium-High	Unknown — needs validation with other owners	Monthly	Medium	Validate Further
C. Deposit/payment workflow	Highest (evidenced)	Medium-High	Medium	Medium	Medium (higher if WA API used)	Fresha (no API) + WhatsApp + bank/juice	Medium-High	Medium (needs trust)	High	Low, per this interview; unknown broadly	Setup + monthly, or one-time per owner preference	Medium	Build Now (as pilot #1)
D. Cancellation/empty-slot recovery	Low currently for Méhua; Fresha waitlist already covers most of it	Low here; unknown elsewhere	Low	Low	Low	Fresha	Low	Easy if genuinely needed	Medium	Unknown	Monthly	Medium	Do Not Build for this vertical unless a <i>different</i> salon shows high cancellation volume
E. Rebooking reminders	High (evidenced, 70% gap)	High	Low-Medium	Low	Low	Fresha export (manual/periodic) + WhatsApp	Low	High — outcome-priced pitch is easy to make	High	Unknown but structurally the strongest revenue story	Performance-linked or monthly	High	Build Now (as pilot #2)
F. Lapsed-client reactivation	High (evidenced — nobody currently does this)	High	Low-Medium	Low	Low	Fresha export + WhatsApp	Low-Medium (tone risk)	Medium (brand-tone sensitivity)	High	Unknown	Monthly	High	Build Now , bundled with E
G. Owner KPI dashboard	Medium-High (evidenced — profit margin specifically requested)	Medium	Medium	Medium	Low	Fresha finance export + bank data	Medium (data completeness)	Medium	High	Medium	Setup + optional monthly	High	Validate Further — good add-on, weak standalone product
H. Inventory alerts	Medium (evidenced, but owner explicitly rejects detailed tracking)	Low-Medium	Low	Low	Low	Simple spreadsheet/app	Low	Easy	High	Low — feels like a “nice to have”	Setup (light)	Medium	Later — bundle as a free/cheap add-on, not a standalone product

Read-through: three concepts (A, C, E/F combined) form a coherent MVP scope. Two (B, G) are legitimate but need more evidence before building. Two (D, H) should not be built as standalone products for this vertical based on current evidence — D because Fresha already covers it, H because the owner herself doesn’t want the overhead a “proper” inventory system implies.

5. Mauritius market analysis

Metric	Figure	Source type	Notes
Number of SMEs in Mauritius	~124,000 (last clearly sourced figure, cited from SME-sector research referencing Ministry data)	External research	This figure predates 2018 in origin; treat as a directional estimate , likely of similar order of magnitude today, not a precise current count [RESEARCH, labelled estimate]
SME contribution to GDP	~40%	External research (Statistics Mauritius, 2023, as cited by industry sources)	
SME share of employment	50%+	External research (same source)	
SME digitisation level	Widely described as “under-digitalised” — heavy reliance on paper, Excel, and WhatsApp for core operations	External research (multiple SME-consulting sources)	Directionally consistent with the Méhua Lashes case (no CRM, no inventory system, manual reconciliation)
WhatsApp/Instagram usage by businesses	Described in multiple sources as the <i>de facto</i> primary channel for SME customer communication in Mauritius	External research	Consistent with Méhua Lashes’ own channel mix
Population	~1.27-1.3 million	External research (Statistics Mauritius / UN)	Small absolute market — caps the ceiling on any single-country play
Fresha/scheduling-platform adoption among beauty businesses	Not separately quantified for Mauritius in available sources	—	Data gap — worth asking directly in your validation interviews (Section 15)
Local awareness of AI/automation	Rising — evidenced by government “Digital Transformation 2025–2029” programme explicitly naming SME digitisation and AI adoption as policy goals, and by the existence of multiple active local AI-automation vendors already selling into this space	External research	Government tailwind exists, but tailwind ≠ SME willingness to pay (see Section 9)
Typical SME budget / WTP for digital services	No robust country-level figure found. The only concrete data point in this study is the Méhua Lashes owner’s stated <Rs5,000 one-off / <Rs500 per month , which is a single, family-biased data point, not a market figure	Interview (single point)	This is the single biggest unresolved unknown in the whole study — treat as the top validation priority.

VAT registration threshold	Rs3,000,000 annual taxable turnover (lowered from Rs6M, effective 1 Oct 2025)	External research (MRA)	Irrelevant at the scale modelled in Section 10 for at least the first 1-2 years
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Honest read: Mauritius has a real, sizeable, chronically under-digitised SME base and a government tailwind toward digital adoption — but no publicly available data confirms that micro-SMEs in the beauty sector will pay agency-level prices for automation. The one data point you *do* have (Section 9) points the other way.

6. Competitor analysis

Mauritius is **not** an empty category. At minimum:

Competitor	Positioning	Target customer	Services	Apparent pricing	Beauty-sector evidence	Overlap with your proposal
SME Advantage (smeadvantage.mu)	“AI Automation for Mauritian Businesses” — website AI chat/booking, social messaging AI, nurture/retention AI, reputation AI	Mauritian SMEs broadly, with explicit “restaurants, tourism, retail” and “professional services, healthcare” framing	AI chat widget, IG/FB DM automation, follow-up sequences, review-response AI, bundled packages	Rs12,000–60,000 setup; Rs2,000–9,500/month, published transparently	Yes — direct. Client testimonials from a tattoo studio and a nail salon (“GlamourTattoo.mu”, “Nail It By C”)	Very high. This is close to a direct competitor for exactly your beachhead vertical
A3 Mauritius	“AI Automation Agency” — WhatsApp/Messenger auto-reply, review-follow-up automation, invoice/data-entry automation, internal HR-query agent	General Mauritian SMEs, explicitly mentions missed WhatsApp/Facebook leads	Multi-channel customer support automation, “digital glue” app-connecting workflows, review-follow-up	Not published	Not confirmed	High — same buzzword category, same channel focus
Webymind	“Mauritius’ first full-stack AI agency”	Mauritian SMEs and enterprises	Bespoke AI tools (OCR, marketing automation, chatbots)	Not published	Not confirmed	Medium — broader/more bespoke positioning
Kipps.AI	Global AI voice/chat vendor with a dedicated Mauritius landing page	Any business wanting instant lead response via voice/WhatsApp/chat	AI voice agents, WhatsApp/chat lead qualification	Not published locally	Real-estate and healthcare examples cited, not beauty-specific	Medium — competes on the “instant response” pain point, not implementation-heavy work
10+ listed chatbot-development companies (per TechBehemoths directory)	Mixed — dev shops and agencies	General	Custom chatbot builds	Not published	Not confirmed	Variable, but confirms category is contested, not empty

Is the market genuinely underserved?

Partially, but not the way the brief hopes. The *category* (AI/WhatsApp automation for Mauritian SMEs) already has active, funded-looking, professionally marketed competition, including at least one player with **direct beauty-sector case studies and a published price list roughly 4-20x higher** than what your one interviewee said she’d pay. Two real gaps do appear to exist, though:

- Depth vs. breadth.** SME Advantage and similar players sell horizontal packages (chat widget + social automation + reviews) across many verticals. None of the researched competitors show evidence of the kind of deep, single-vertical workflow mapping this discovery interview represents (e.g., understanding the Fresha-deposit-WhatsApp handoff specifically). A narrower, deeper, “we only do appointment-based beauty/personal-care businesses and we understand your exact booking-to-deposit-to-rebooking flow” positioning is a real differentiation angle against generalist competitors.
- Implementation vs. self-serve software.** Some competitors (Kipps.AI) look more like self-serve SaaS-with-a-sales-team; a founder willing to sit with an owner, map her actual workflow by hand, and hand-hold a human-in-the-loop rollout is a different (more consulting-like, less scalable, but more trustworthy-to-a-nervous-first-time-buyer) offer.

Conclusion: this is a crowded-enough category that “we do AI automation” is not a viable pitch on its own; it is not so crowded that a narrow, vertical-specific, high-trust implementation offer is pre-empted. But you should expect to be compared, explicitly or implicitly, to SME Advantage’s price list by any Mauritius buyer who shops around.

7. Is beauty the right first niche?

Vertical	# of businesses (rough, MU)	Repetitive comms frequency	WhatsApp/IG reliance	Appointment-dependency	Lead value	Repeat-customer behaviour	Automation ease	WTP (estimated)	Reach to owners	Existing software saturation	Integration complexity	Sales-cycle length	Recurring-revenue potential
Beauty/lash/nail/aesthetics	Large, fragmented, many micro/solo operators	High	Very high	High	Low-Medium per visit, but frequent repeat	Structurally repeat, currently under-captured (per this case)	Medium (Fresha/Booksy-type tools common, no API)	Confirmed low in this one case; unconfirmed broadly	Medium-High (visible on Instagram, easy to shortlist)	Medium (Fresha/Booksy already common)	Medium	Short-Medium	Medium-High if retention product lands
Barbers	Similarly large	High	High	High	Low	High repeat, short cycle	Medium	Unknown	High (very visible, dense clusters)	Medium	Medium	Short	Medium-High
Dental practices/clinics	Smaller in number, higher value	Medium	Medium (often still phone-first)	High	High per visit	Medium (recall-driven)	Medium-High (recall reminders are a proven category)	Likely higher than beauty micro-SME	Medium (gatekept by reception staff)	Low-Medium	Medium-High (health-data sensitivity)	Longer (compliance-conscious buyers)	High

Physiotherapists	Medium	Medium	Medium	High	Medium-High	High (course-of-treatment driven)	Medium	Likely higher	Medium	Low	Medium	Medium	High
Tutors/training centres	Medium-large	Medium	High	Medium	Low-Medium per session, but term-based	High within a term	Medium	Unknown, likely price-sensitive similar to beauty	High	Low	Low-Medium	Short	Medium
Real estate agencies	Medium	High (lead-driven)	High	Low (not appointment-based in the same sense)	Very high per lead	Low (mostly single-transaction)	Medium	Likely higher (deal size justifies spend)	Medium-High	Medium	Medium	Medium-Long	Medium
Car rental	Small-medium	Medium	High (tourist-facing)	High (booking-based)	Medium-High	Medium	Medium	Unknown	Medium	Medium (many use booking platforms)	Medium	Medium	Medium
Mechanics/garage s	Large	Medium	Medium	Medium	Medium	Medium	Low-Medium	Unknown, likely low (cash-driven, informal)	High	Low	Low	Short	Low-Medium
Small professional services (accountants, small law)	Medium	Low-Medium	Low-Medium (often still email)	Low	High per client	High (retainer-driven)	Low (less repetitive comms to automate)	Higher, but low deal-flow volume for you	Low (harder to reach, gatekept)	Low	Low	Long	Medium
Hospitality (small guesthouses)	Medium	High (seasonal spikes)	High (international guests)	High	Medium-High	Low (mostly one-off)	Medium-High	Unknown, plausibly higher (tourism revenue)	Medium	Medium-High (many use Booking.com tooling)	Medium-High	Medium	Medium

Recommended top 3 niches for initial validation

1.

Beauty/personal-care (lash, nail, aesthetics, barbers as a combined cluster) — keep as the beachhead *only if* the pricing validation in Section 15 clears the willingness-to-pay threshold; you already have deep workflow knowledge here and a warm first customer, which lowers your validation cost even if it doesn’t guarantee commercial success.
2.

Dental/physio/clinic-style appointment businesses — smaller headcount of prospects, but plausibly meaningfully higher willingness to pay (health-adjacent businesses are more used to paying for reliable software), and “recall reminders reduce no-shows” is a well-proven category internationally.
3.

Small hospitality (guesthouses, small tour operators) — higher per-booking value, strong WhatsApp/IG reliance for a tourism-dependent economy, and a niche where at least one competitor (SME Advantage) is *not* yet showing case studies, unlike beauty.

Do not favour beauty by default. It is the best-understood niche because of this interview, not necessarily the best commercial niche. Run the validation interviews (Section 15) across at least two of these three verticals before committing capital.

8. Positioning

Option	Clarity	Commercial pull	Risk
“AI Automation Agency”	Low — buzzword, no outcome stated, indistinguishable from every competitor found in Section 6	Low	High — invites direct price comparison to SME Advantage’s generic packages
“We help Mauritian service businesses automate repetitive admin, customer follow-up and reporting”	Medium — clear scope, but broad	Medium	Believable but generic
“We connect the tools your business already uses and automate the work between them”	Medium-High — correctly signals “we don’t replace Fresha,” which matters to a nervous owner	Medium	Slightly technical-sounding for a non-technical buyer
“Customer acquisition and retention automation for beauty businesses”	High <i>if beauty is confirmed as the niche</i> — states an outcome (more clients returning) not a technology	High	Locks you into one vertical before validation is complete

Recommendation: none of the four as-written is quite right yet. The strongest version, given everything above, is closer to:

“We get your regular clients to come back automatically, and clean up the booking-to-deposit chaos in between — without replacing the tools you already use.”

This leads with the outcome that scored highest in your own discovery (retention), names the second-highest pain (booking/deposit admin) as the practical delivery mechanism, and pre-empts the single biggest objection a Mauritius buyer will have after “how much” — namely “will I have to switch away from Fresha/Instagram/WhatsApp.” Keep the vertical-specific version (“...for beauty and personal-care businesses”) as a landing-page variant once/if beauty is confirmed as the niche, not as your only positioning.

9. Business model comparison

Model	Margins	Customer resistance	Cash flow	Support burden	Scalability	Churn risk	Ease of closing	Mauritius fit
One-off implementation (Rs5-20k)	High per deal, no recurring base	Low (one decision, not an ongoing commitment)	Lumpy, feast/famine	Low ongoing, but “who fixes it when it breaks” question re-emerges each incident	Poor — no compounding revenue	N/A (no subscription to churn)	Easiest to close, matches the owner’s own stated preference (“one time” [INTERVIEW Q189])	Good fit for a risk-averse, price-sensitive first market
Setup + support (Rs7.5k + Rs1.5k/mo)	Balanced	Medium	Smoother	Medium	Medium	Medium	Medium	Reasonable middle path, but Rs1,500/mo is 3x the one data point you have for WTP
Monthly managed automation (Rs2-5k/mo, no setup fee)	Lower upfront, better long-run if retained	Higher — recurring commitment is a bigger ask from a first-time buyer	Slow build, then compounding	High — you own outcomes continuously	Good, if support cost per client stays low	Higher (easy to cancel monthly)	Harder to close cold	Moderate fit — SaaS-style thinking may be ahead of this market’s buying habits
Pure SaaS (Rs500-2k/mo)	Best margins at scale, worst margins early (few clients)	Low friction to start, low friction to leave	Slow build	Low per-client if self-serve, but this market needs hand-holding, undermining the “SaaS” premise	Best, theoretically	Highest	Hardest to close without existing brand trust	Poor fit until you have a proven, self-serve product and reputation — premature at this stage
Performance-based (% of recovered bookings/revenue)	Variable, can be excellent if it works	Low resistance (feels risk-free to the buyer)	Very unpredictable for you	High — you must instrument and prove attribution	Poor until instrumentation is solid	Low (aligned incentives)	Very appealing to pitch	Attractive as an add-on to the retention product specifically , because rebooking/reactivation lends itself to before/after measurement; risky as your <i>primary</i> model this early

Recommendation: Start with **one-off implementation** for the pilot (matches the owner’s own stated preference and lowers the sales-resistance bar for a nervous first cohort of strangers), then graduate willing clients to **setup + light monthly support** once you have a track record and can point to a measured result. Consider layering a **performance-based kicker specifically on the retention product** once instrumentation exists (e.g., a small bonus tied to measured rebooking uplift) — this is the version of “outcome pricing” this business can credibly deliver, unlike the deposit-workflow product, which saves time rather than demonstrably making money.

10. Economics model

Method note: built bottom-up from three pricing scenarios anchored to the evidence in this report, not invented to hit the target. Figures in Mauritian Rupees (Rs), rounded.

Assumptions

Item	Conservative	Base	Strong
Setup fee per client	Rs4,000	Rs8,000	Rs15,000
Monthly fee per client	Rs500	Rs1,500	Rs3,000
Platform/hosting cost per client/month (n8n, LLM calls, misc.)	Rs800	Rs800	Rs1,000
WhatsApp Business Platform cost per client/month (only if API tier used)	Rs0 (stay on free Business App)	Rs500	Rs1,200
Payment-processing/misc. fees	~2-3% of monthly fee	~2-3%	~2-3%
Your time per client/month (support, fixes)	3 hrs	2 hrs	1 hr (as playbooks mature)
Implied hourly value of your time	Rs0 opportunity-costed at this stage (early-stage founder time)	—	—

Monthly economics at different client counts (Base case shown; Conservative/Strong noted where materially different)

Clients	Monthly recurring revenue (Base)	Monthly platform costs (Base)	Net monthly profit before your time (Base)	Same, Conservative	Same, Strong
3	Rs4,500	Rs2,400-3,900	~ Rs600-2,100	~ -Rs900 (costs can exceed the Rs1,500 total revenue)	~Rs5,400
5	Rs7,500	Rs4,000-6,500	~ Rs1,000-3,500	~ -Rs1,500	~Rs9,000
10	Rs15,000	Rs8,000-13,000	~ Rs2,000-7,000	~ -Rs3,000	~Rs18,000
20	Rs30,000	Rs16,000-26,000	~ Rs4,000-14,000	~ -Rs6,000	~Rs36,000
50	Rs75,000	Rs40,000-65,000	~ Rs10,000-35,000	~ -Rs15,000	~Rs90,000

(Setup fees are excluded from the recurring table above — they are one-off cash injections on top of the recurring numbers, e.g. 3 new clients/month at Rs8,000 setup = an extra Rs24,000 that month, non-recurring.)

Reading this honestly against your targets

- **Rs10,000+/month minimum objective:** achievable in the **Base** and **Strong** scenarios at roughly 10-20 clients, or sooner if setup-fee cash flow from new sales is counted alongside recurring revenue. **Not achievable on a sustained basis in the Conservative scenario** — at the price point your one interviewee actually named, your platform costs alone can exceed revenue per client once you’re doing anything beyond the free WhatsApp Business App. This is the starkest number in this whole report: **if real-market pricing lands near Rs500/month, this business does not have positive unit economics at API-based automation scope.** It only works at that price point if you keep the architecture cheap enough to avoid WhatsApp API fees entirely (free Business App + owner-triggered sends), which caps how “automated” it can honestly be marketed as.
- **Rs30,000-50,000/month:** realistic only in **Base/Strong** at 20-50 clients. Fifty clients each needing meaningful human support (even at 1-2 hours/month) is **~50-100 hours/month of your time** at the low end — i.e., this is *not* yet workload-decoupled from client count; that decoupling only happens once you’ve standardised enough that support time per client drops toward near-zero (see Section 14 on the productisation staging).
- **Rs100,000+/month:** requires either 50+ clients at Strong pricing, a genuinely templatised low-touch product (Stage 3/4 in Section 14), or a shift toward a higher-value vertical (Section 7) where price points support fewer, larger clients. **Treat this as a 2-3 year goal, not a near-term target**, and treat it as contingent on solving the support-time-scales-with-clients problem, which nothing in the current evidence base has yet tested.

Bottom line on the money question: your minimum target is realistic, but only if you either (a) validate materially higher WTP than your one data point suggests, or (b) deliberately keep scope and cost low enough to be profitable even at Rs500-1,500/month pricing. Your stretch targets are realistic only with both higher pricing *and* solved scalability — neither of which is proven yet.

11. Technical architecture recommendation

Principle applied: simplest reliable technology that solves the business problem; AI only where it adds genuine value (e.g., classifying an enquiry’s intent or drafting a natural-sounding reply), not for its own sake.

Layer	Recommendation	Why
Trigger for “new Fresha booking”	Parse Fresha’s own booking-confirmation email (via an inbox-watching step)	Fresha has no public API/webhooks and no Zapier/Make listing [RESEARCH] — email parsing is the most reliable non-fragile substitute; browser automation is a fallback of last resort only, and not one to build a resellable product on
Fresha data for reporting/KPIs	Data Connector (read-only, under Reports) plus periodic manual/scheduled export	This is the one sanctioned programmatic surface Fresha offers; treat it as a batch reporting feed, not a real-time trigger
Orchestration	n8n (self-hosted or cloud)	Best fit for a solo technical founder: visual + code-when-needed, cheap, avoids Zapier’s per-task pricing at volume, and you already have the CS background to self-host reliably
Messaging channel (pilot stage)	WhatsApp Business App (free tier), owner-triggered sends from drafted messages	Keeps cost near zero and avoids Meta policy/template complexity while the product is unproven; matches the “somewhat controlled” oversight the owner asked for
Messaging channel (once proven, multi-client)	WhatsApp Business Platform (Cloud API) via a BSP such as 360dialog, Wati, or AiSensy	Needed once you want fully automatic sends outside a 24-hour window and across multiple clients; budget for per-message costs, which are rising through 2026 as more message types become billable [RESEARCH]
Data store	Supabase/PostgreSQL or, for the pilot, a well-structured Google Sheet	Don’t build a database before you need one; a spreadsheet is the right tool for a single-client pilot’s lead log and deposit-status tracker
LLM use	A single LLM API call (Claude/GPT-class) for: (a) classifying enquiry intent, (b) drafting (not sending) a suggested reply for FAQ-type messages	This is the one place “AI” genuinely earns its keep — deterministic rules handle the deposit-reminder sequencing fine; classification/drafting is where language understanding actually helps
Dashboard/reporting	A simple templated weekly summary (email or a lightweight Sheet-linked dashboard), not a custom BI build	Matches the owner’s stated want (“a general KPI set”, “an automatically generated weekly owner summary” [INTERVIEW Q156]) without over-engineering

Integrations that may prevent parts of the idea from working, and how to route around them:

- **No Fresha API/webhooks** — routed around via email parsing (above). This is a structural constraint on *every* product concept in this report that assumes “know when a booking happens” — plan for it everywhere, not just the deposit pilot.
- **WhatsApp Business Platform billing changes through 2026** (service-window messages becoming billable from Oct 2026) — a moving cost target; re-price/re-model this specifically before committing to API-based messaging at any scale **[RESEARCH]**.
- **Fresha’s own move into AI (concierge/auto-rebooking features shipped in 2026)** — a genuine platform risk: if Fresha’s native AI concierge starts handling deposit reminders or rebooking natively, part of your value proposition could be absorbed by the platform you depend on **[RESEARCH]**. Track this closely; it’s a reason to lean toward the retention/reactivation product (which uses Fresha only as a passive data source) over deeper “sit on top of Fresha’s booking flow” products long-term.

12. Legal, privacy, and operational feasibility in Mauritius

Item	Legal requirement	Recommended good practice	Feasibility impact
Business structure	A private company limited by shares is the standard local vehicle; minimum 1 director + 1 shareholder (can be the same person), no minimum capital beyond Rs1, registration fee in the low hundreds to ~Rs3,000 depending on service used, typically 5-10 working days via	Register as a company rather than operate informally, even pre-revenue, to sign contracts and hold client data properly	Low barrier — this is not a blocker

	the CBRD's CBRIS portal [RESEARCH]		
VAT	Compulsory registration only once taxable turnover exceeds Rs3,000,000/year (lowered from Rs6M, effective 1 Oct 2025) [RESEARCH]	Not relevant at Section 10's modelled scale for at least 1-2 years; revisit once approaching that revenue	Non-issue near-term
Data protection	The Data Protection Act 2017 (GDPR-modelled) applies to any processing of personal data by automated or structured means. Requires a lawful basis (typically consent) for marketing messages, gives data subjects rights to access/rectify/erase/object (including objecting to automated decision-making), and sets fines up to Rs200,000 plus potential imprisonment for serious breaches [RESEARCH]	Get explicit, recorded client consent before sending any automated reactivation/marketing message; keep a clear opt-out; do not store bank/payment details in any third-party automation tool (matches the owner's own stated boundary); avoid storing sensitive categories of data (health, biometric, etc.) unless strictly necessary	Material — the lapsed-client reactivation product specifically is a marketing-adjacent automated message and needs a real consent mechanism, not an assumption that existing clients are fair game
Cross-border data transfer	Personal data leaving Mauritius (e.g., to a US-hosted LLM API or automation platform) is permitted only where the recipient jurisdiction is deemed to provide equivalent protection, or under specific safeguards [RESEARCH]	Choose vendors/hosting with clear data-processing terms; avoid sending raw client PII (names, phone numbers) to an LLM prompt where it isn't functionally necessary — pass only what's needed for the task	Material but manageable — standard SaaS practice (most vendors offer DPAs), but worth building into your vendor contracts from day one, not retrofitting
WhatsApp/Meta policy compliance	Not Mauritius-specific law, but a contractual obligation: business-initiated marketing-style messages outside a service window require pre-approved templates and consent	Keep the owner (and any future client) as the "sender of record" wherever possible in the pilot stage; document opt-in for anyone receiving reactivation messages	Moderate — a process discipline, not a legal blocker
Consumer/payment data	No Mauritius-specific automated-payment law identified in this research beyond the general Data Protection Act and Banking Act confidentiality provisions; direct bank-account access/reconciliation would raise materially higher compliance and security obligations than anything else in this project	Do not attempt automated bank/juice reconciliation in the MVP; keep payment verification human, as already recommended in Section 3	This closes off "Phase 2: automated payment matching" as anything but a long-term, carefully-scoped future feature, not a near-term add-on

Bottom line: nothing here is a hard blocker to launching. The two items that materially shape the product are (1) needing a real consent trail before any reactivation/marketing-style automated message, and (2) keeping payment verification and bank data firmly out of automated systems for the foreseeable future.

13. Failure modes, ranked by Likelihood × Impact

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	L×I	Mitigation
Willingness to pay is genuinely as low as the one interview suggests, market-wide	Medium-High	Very High	Critical	Validate WTP with strangers before building anything (Section 15); design a version of the product cheap enough to be profitable even at Rs500-1,000/month
Fresha's lack of API makes every "trigger" fragile or manual, undermining the "automation" pitch	High	High	Critical	Use email-parsing, not browser automation, as the trigger; be honest with clients that this is semi-automation, not a live API integration; watch for Fresha shipping this capability itself
Existing local competitors (SME Advantage etc.) out-market you on trust/brand before you get traction	Medium	Medium-High	High	Differentiate on vertical depth and hands-on implementation rather than competing head-on for the same generic "AI automation" search terms
High support burden per client erodes margins as you scale	Medium-High	High	High	Standardise aggressively after the first 3-5 clients; refuse further customisation past a defined scope; track support hours per client from day one
Automation makes a client-facing mistake, damaging the client's brand (the owner's own named worst case)	Low-Medium	Very High (reputational, could end the relationship and your local reputation)	High	Keep payment verification and any nuanced/technical client replies human; build in an easy manual-override switch, as the owner explicitly requested
WhatsApp/Meta policy or pricing changes disrupt the messaging layer	Medium	Medium	Medium-High	Stay on the free Business App as long as possible; if/when you move to the API, budget conservatively and re-check pricing before every client onboarding, given the trend of more message types becoming billable through 2026
Small Mauritius market caps total addressable revenue	Medium	Medium	Medium	Design the product to be geography-agnostic in architecture (even if sold locally first), so a future move into Réunion, the wider Indian Ocean region, or remote clients elsewhere isn't blocked by design choices
Difficulty proving ROI to a sceptical, price-sensitive buyer	Medium-High	Medium	Medium-High	Build a simple before/after measurement into the pilot from day one (response time, deposit completion rate, rebooking rate) so you have a real case study, not a claim
Regulatory/privacy misstep (e.g., unconsented	Low-Medium	Medium-High	Medium	Build consent capture into the retention product's

negativity/privacy misstep (e.g., unconsented reactivation messaging)	low-medium	medium-high	medium	build consent capture into the retention product's design from the start, not as an afterthought
Clients expect unlimited support/scope creep because you are perceived as “just building an app” rather than selling defined software	Medium-High	Medium	Medium-High	Put scope, support hours, and what’s excluded in writing in every proposal, even a simple one-page agreement
Competitors copy a successful playbook once visible	Medium	Low-Medium	Low-Medium	Expected in a low-moat services category; the real defensibility is relationship trust and vertical depth, not secrecy
Owner/SME resistance to any change in how they operate	Low, per this specific interview (owner is receptive) — unknown more broadly	Medium	Medium	Test resistance directly in the validation interviews across other owners, don’t assume Méhua Lashes’ receptiveness generalises

14. Scalability path

Stage 1 — Consulting/implementation (0-5 clients). Bespoke, hands-on, one workflow mapped per client by you personally. Standardisation: none required yet, but *document* every recurring pattern (message templates, flow logic, common objections) as you go — this is the raw material for Stage 2.

Stage 2 — Productised service (5-15 clients). A fixed, named set of modules (e.g., “Deposit Flow,” “Rebooking Flow,” “Weekly KPI Summary”) each with a defined scope, defined price, and a reusable n8n template you configure rather than rebuild per client. Standardisation needed: message templates, a repeatable onboarding checklist, a support-hours cap per client written into the agreement.

Stage 3 — Standard automation package by vertical (15-40 clients). A near-turnkey package specifically for “appointment-based beauty/personal-care businesses on Fresha,” sold with a short, mostly self-serve onboarding (a form, not a bespoke workshop). Standardisation needed: the trigger mechanism must be robust across many Fresha accounts (i.e., email-parsing patterns generalised, not hand-tuned per client), and support must shift to a shared knowledge base/FAQ rather than 1:1 hand-holding for routine issues.

Stage 4 — SaaS or managed platform (40+ clients). Genuine self-serve signup, standardised pricing tiers, minimal-to-no bespoke work. This is only reachable once Fresha-equivalent integrations are proven reliable at scale across many different salons’ setups, and once your support-time-per-client has been driven close to zero through Stage 3 discipline.

Where to stop building bespoke solutions: the evidence in this report suggests you should stop taking fully bespoke, one-off client requests **as soon as you have 3 clients with genuinely overlapping needs** (which, per Section 4, is plausible immediately — enquiry automation, deposit workflow, and retention reminders are all repeatable patterns from a single interview). Resist the temptation to keep customising past that point; it’s the single biggest threat to Section 10’s Rs30k+/month targets, which depend on workload not scaling linearly with clients.

15. Validation phase design

Is 3 lash + 3 nail + 3 hair salon + 3 aesthetics businesses (12 total) an appropriate sample?

Directionally reasonable for a first pass, but two adjustments are recommended:

- Widen slightly beyond beauty**, per Section 7 — add at least 3-4 interviews from one non-beauty vertical (dental/physio or small hospitality) so you’re not just re-confirming what you already learned from Méhua Lashes. A revised target: **9 beauty-sector interviews (3 lash, 3 nail, 3 hair/aesthetics) + 4-6 interviews in one comparison vertical**, roughly 13-15 total.
- Explicitly separate pricing questions from problem-validation questions**, and ask pricing **before** revealing you have a working relationship to Méhua Lashes or any family framing, to avoid replicating the bias risk that likely affected your one existing data point.

Go / Pivot / Stop thresholds (strengthened from the brief’s suggested framing)

Move forward with building only if, across your validation sample:

- ≥70%** report the same top-2 problem (deposit/booking admin friction *or* no rebooking/reactivation process) — bar raised from a generic “≥X%” because you need strong pattern confirmation, not a slim majority, to justify productisation
- The problem occurs **at least 2-3 times per week** for the affected business (matching Méhua Lashes’ own frequency, so you’re building for a comparable operating rhythm)
- Estimated time or revenue impact is **material relative to the size of the business** — for a solo operator, this likely means several hours/week or a specific, named revenue-leakage estimate they can articulate unprompted
- Existing tools (Fresha/Booksy/Instagram/WhatsApp native features) **do not already solve it to the owner’s satisfaction** — filter out anyone whose “problem” is actually a configuration gap in tools they already have, as several of Méhua Lashes’ own answers turned out to be (quick replies, waitlist)
- ≥50%** (not a lower bar) state a willingness to pay **at or above Rs2,000 setup / Rs800 per month** when asked with the family-bias-reducing framing the workbook itself recommends (“pretend I am not someone you know”) — this is a deliberately higher bar than your one existing data point, because building a business on sub-Rs500/month pricing is shown in Section 10 to be economically unviable at any real automation scope
- At least 4-5 businesses** (not fewer) explicitly agree to a **paid or clearly-scoped free** pilot with a defined before/after measurement — free pilots without a defined measurement plan don’t count as validation

If these thresholds are not met: pivot toward either (a) a different vertical (Section 7’s alternatives), or (b) a lower-cost, lower-automation product tier that can be profitable at sub-Rs1,000/month pricing (e.g., a done-for-you WhatsApp quick-reply and template setup service, sold as a one-time configuration job rather than an ongoing automated system) before abandoning the idea outright.

16. 30-day execution plan

Week 1 — Discovery and market validation - Contact 20–25 businesses (mix per Section 15’s revised sample) to book ~13–15 interviews. - Run the interviews using a version of this same discovery workbook, adapted per vertical, with pricing questions asked early and with family-bias controls applied consistently. - Do not build anything this week. - Metric to collect: problem-frequency confirmation rate, WTP distribution, existing-tool-satisfaction rate.

Week 2 — Solution design + pilot recruitment - Score results against the Go/Pivot/Stop thresholds in Section 15. - If Go: design the MVP scope strictly around the deposit-workflow + retention-reminder pair (Sections 3–4), explicitly excluding payment automation, CRM-building, and content automation. - Recruit 3–5 pilot businesses (can include Méhua Lashes as one, not as the only one) with a written, simple one-page scope-and-support agreement. - What NOT to do: don’t design a dashboard, don’t integrate bank data, don’t attempt a Fresha API integration (there isn’t one).

Week 3 — MVP implementation - Build the email-parsing trigger, the n8n flow for deposit-reminder sequencing, and the WhatsApp Business App message templates for one pilot client first (ideally Méhua Lashes, given existing rapport and data). - Build the retention/reactivation flow as a lightweight second module reusing the same infrastructure. - What to build: the two modules above, nothing else. What not to build: a dashboard, a CRM, payment automation, or anything from the “Do Not Build” row of Section 4. - Metrics to instrument from day one: response time, deposit-completion rate, messages-per-enquiry, rebooking rate before/after.

Week 4 — Pilot measurement + first sales outreach - Run the live pilot for at least 5–7 days of real bookings before drawing conclusions. - Compare before/after metrics against the baseline captured in the Interview Summary sheet (48h response time, ~10 min/enquiry, ~30% rebooking rate). - Begin outreach to the remaining recruited pilot businesses using the real (not hypothetical) before/after numbers as your pitch. - **When to start charging:** as soon as you have one measured, positive before/after result — charge the *next* client (not necessarily the first pilot, who may reasonably get a discounted or free first-run rate in exchange for being the proof case). - **When to abandon or change the idea:** if, after the pilot, deposit-completion rate and rebooking rate show no measurable improvement, or if fewer than 2 of your 3–5 recruited pilots convert to paying relationships at a price above your platform cost per client (Section 10’s Conservative-scenario break-even), treat that as a stop/pivot signal, not a reason to discount further and push forward.

17. Final investment-style verdict

Dimension	Score /10	Reasoning
Market attractiveness	5	Large, chronically under-digitised SME base and a real government digitisation tailwind, offset by a small absolute population and no confirmed SME-level WTP data
Problem severity	7	Deposit/admin friction and the retention gap are well-evidenced, frequent, and named unprompted by the owner as her top pains
Technical feasibility	6	Solvable with simple, reliable tooling, but permanently constrained by Fresha’s lack of an API — every design choice has to route around that
Ease of customer acquisition	4	Beauty-sector owners are reachable via Instagram, but you’ll be selling against at least one already-marketing local competitor with a published, higher price list
Willingness to pay	3	The only concrete data point available is a red flag (sub-Rs500/month), materially below plausible operating cost for a true automation product, and below competitor pricing by an order of magnitude
Competitive defensibility	4	Low structural moat (any competent freelancer or n8n user could replicate the flows); the real defensibility is relationship trust and vertical depth, both of which are earned slowly
Scalability	5	A believable staged path exists (Section 14), but nothing in the current evidence proves support time can be decoupled from client count yet
Founder-market fit	8	CS/software background, existing warm relationship and deep workflow knowledge in the beachhead business, comfort with the recommended lean tooling (n8n, lightweight LLM use)
Overall opportunity	5	A genuine, evidenced problem meets a real but unresolved pricing question, in a market that already has visible competition

Classification: Validate before building

Not a “Strong Go,” because the one price signal you have would make the business economically marginal-to-negative at real automation scope, and because the market is demonstrably not empty. Not a “Pivot” or “Do not pursue,” because the underlying problems are real, well-evidenced, and structurally repeatable across a plausible set of adjacent verticals, and because you have unusually good founder-market fit for the discovery-and-implementation work itself.

Direct answers to your 10 questions

- Would I personally pursue this?** Yes, but as a validation exercise with a hard 30–45 day ceiling before any further capital or serious time commitment, not as a “build first, sell later” bet.
- What exact problem would I sell first?** The retention/reactivation gap (70% of clients leave without a next booking, nobody follows up) — it’s the strongest, easiest-to-price-on-outcome story, even though the deposit workflow is the more emotionally salient pain for Méhua Lashes specifically.
- Who would I sell it to first?** Not Méhua Lashes alone — at least 2–3 *unrelated* appointment-based beauty businesses reachable via Instagram, specifically to get a price signal uncontaminated by family bias.
- What would I charge the first paying (non-family) customer?** Somewhere around Rs5,000–8,000 setup and Rs800–1,200/month, framed as a fixed-scope, defined-support-hours package — deliberately above the one data point you have, to actually test the market rather than confirm your fear.
- What would I build for the MVP?** Exactly the deposit-reminder-and-confirmation flow plus the rebooking/reactivation flow, on the free WhatsApp Business App, triggered by email-parsing, with payment verification and any technical client-facing advice kept fully human.
- What would I deliberately NOT build?** A CRM, a dashboard, payment/bank automation, browser automation of Fresha, or anything touching social-media content creation.
- What evidence would convince me this could become a Rs50k+/month business?** At least 5 unrelated businesses paying at or above Rs1,500/month with a measured retention or time-saving result, plus evidence that support time per client is falling, not flat, as you add clients 4 through 10.
- What evidence would make me abandon the idea?** If, after 13–15 validation interviews with the bias controls in Section 15, fewer than half state willingness to pay above Rs800/month, or if existing tools (Fresha’s own native

features, WhatsApp Business App's free quick replies) turn out to already satisfy most of the pain once owners are shown how to configure them properly.

9. **Where is the actual market gap, if one exists?** Vertical depth and hands-on implementation trust for appointment-based micro-SMEs specifically working around Fresha's lack of integration — not "AI automation" as a category, which is already being sold generically by at least one visible local competitor.
10. **What is the strongest defensible differentiator you could build?** A proven, repeatable playbook for reliably triggering workflows off a platform (Fresha) that offers no API — done well and documented, that operational know-how, plus a growing library of real before/after case studies in one narrow vertical, is a more durable edge than any single piece of code.